They reckoned without the American resolve. The nuclear deal had become one of the defining legacies of the Bush administration, and it was determined to remove barriers to its successful conclusion. America was the world's only superpower; it was at its zenith. When the NSG resumed its meeting in early September 2008, China's official spokesman continued to say that there were different opinions in the NSG [24] and continued to hide behind them. However, in the recess, the American Secretary of State had worked the phones, speaking to Western counterparts, to drop their opposition. [25] The Group of Six, behind which China had hidden for so long, were picked off one-by-one, until on the night of 5 September, China remained the last man standing. They threatened to withdraw from the negotiations, which would have meant there was no consensus. It is reported that calls were made from Washington to Beijing at the highest levels in the administration. Simultaneously, at 3 a.m. in the early hours of 6 September, the Chinese Ambassador was awakened in New Delhi, and informed in clear terms that China stood alone in opposition, and if it didn't shift its position, it would affect the overall India–China relationship. [26] The Chinese folded just before dawn on 6 September. The head of its delegation, Tang Guoqiang, refused to be present at the formal NSG meeting, sending his deputy instead. They abstained on the vote, thus allowing the consensus in the NSG on giving India a clean and unconditional waiver to move forward.

It may never be possible to know the reason for the Chinese volte-face, but pragmatism is a hallmark of Chinese negotiating strategy and tactics. Perhaps China felt that they had much bigger global stakes with the Americans; perhaps they were embarrassed at being exposed and felt it was not good for them vis-à-vis India. [27] The Chinese publicly declared that their participation had always been with a responsible and